# MAPPING MY STORY

| List your relationship problems by category: | Circumstantial:<br><br>Situational issues due to context. | Perpetual:<br><br>The patterns and problems you always argue about. | Gridlocked:<br><br>The things you can no longer talk about: |
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## Now it's time to prepare for your intentional conversation

*Prioritize one of your problems to discuss with your partner and run it through the below process so you can do your part of making the problem your problem, not your partner.*

**How to LEAD WITH MY NEED and *empower* my partner:**

You need to start with asking yourself these self reflection:

- What is my unmet need in this problem (love, security, connection etc)?
- What do I want here; what's my goal?
- Is what I'm about to say going to lead me closer to or further away from my goal?
- Can I say this with gentleness and respect?
- Does my partner feel connected to me and appreciated?

***Problems are Problems, not People.***

Once your need is clarified, you are ready for the **WHEN, THEN, THIS** construction for an **intentional conversation** with your partner.

**GUIDE POSTS:**

- Keep to your side by speaking strictly from your perspective (be humble, not authoritative or righteous)
- Take full responsibility for your thoughts and feelings without blame (no criticism).
- Stay focused on only this particular incident or event (rabbit trails lead to criticism).
- Stay focused on behavior rather than attitude or character.
- Offer your partner clear achievable ways or behaviors that would meet your need

**WHEN/THEN/THIS:** How to be responsible for your own emotions and behaviors and really BE HEARD AND UNDERSTOOD by your partner.

Choose a **WHEN** (with gentleness & respect):

WHEN--------- happens (ed),
WHEN I hear (d) ---------
WHEN I perceive (d) --------
WHEN I see/saw ---------

Proceed to **THEN**:

COUPLE FORWARD

**THEN** my instinct responds (or I protect myself) with ---------- (secondary EMOTION: Disapproval, Disdain, Hatred, Coldness, Hostility, Persecution Complex, Paranoia, Distrust, Jealousy, Worry, Anxiety, Insecurity, Low Self Esteem, Self-hatred, Depression, Anger/Rage)

**because I experience ----------** (primary EMOTION: Joy, Happiness Satisfaction, Fulfillment, Contentment Peace, Fear, Shame, Sadness, Hurt, Guilt, Frustration, Dissatisfaction, Disappointment)

**THEN I make up and tell myself this story about this problem?** (Example:I tell myself it is hopeless, they have a personality problem, I'm stupid, I'm not good enough, I'm the problem

Proceed to **THIS**:

COUPLE FORWARD

**This**: _____ is what I need from you. (Remember to be specific and have the attitude that you are asking for something to help, making a request, not blaming them) YOU OWN YOUR PRIMARY EMOTIONAL MAP, NOT THEM.

***WE ARE NOT RESPONSIBLE FOR OUR PARTNERS EMOTIONS OR THOUGHTS, OUR RESPONSIBILITY IS TO BE RESPONSIVE***

Or...I've thought about what might help me _____.

**Final step: GIVE UP THE ILLUSION OF CONTROL:**

*You cannot directly control your partner, and you cannot directly control how the system operates as a whole. You can't control the outcome. The only part of the relationship that is under your direct control is you—and that is on a good day! Give up the mad agenda of "getting" your partner to change. You stop asking your partner to heal you and start seeing your relationship as the crucible in which you get to heal yourself. The best you can hope for is having influence and a partner that responds non defensively and is open to helping you with your problem, your emotions, and your needs. You have to start thinking relationally, systemically. You are not above your relationship working on it, the way a mechanic works on a car. You are working on yourself inside the relationship. You are a part of the system. You move within it. You move with humility. This relationship is likely the final adult development stage and test of you being healthy.*

COUPLE FORWARD

**Proceed to Intentional conversation**

**Intentional conversations are defined as specific limited time, specific limited subject.**

*Now you are ready to have an intentional conversation. Invite your partner and ask them is they are willing to just listen before they respond.*